



Very cold 24/11 • Tomorrow: Cloudy, cold 20/14 **B20**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

FRIDAY, JANUARY 30, 2026 • \$4

Impasse hit on key Ukraine condition

Russia dismisses security guarantees Kyiv seeks in U.S.-brokered deal

BY DAVID L. STERN,
LIZZIE JOHNSON AND
ANASTACIA GALOUCHKA

KYIV — Despite optimistic pronouncements from President Donald Trump and other U.S. officials about imminent results in efforts to resolve the Russia-Ukraine conflict, Moscow's top diplomat on Thursday rejected a central condition of the proposed deal.

Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov dismissed a bilateral security agreement between the United States and Ukraine — a key condition Kyiv that officials say is needed for them to sign any deal — saying “that such security guarantees are unlikely to ensure lasting peace.”

The minister's statement threw into doubt the fundamental basis of ongoing talks, namely that Ukraine will trust a peace agreement with Russia if its security is guaranteed by the United States.

Details of the security agreement are not known, but Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky said this week that the U.S.-provided guarantees were “100 percent ready” for signing. Meanwhile, Secretary of State Marco Rubio told a Senate Foreign Relations Committee hearing Wednesday that “you could argue” that the guarantees “are agreed to from our side of the equation.”

Lavrov told journalists in Moscow that he did not know the specifics of the agreement, but he said that “apparently, these are guarantees for the very Ukrainian

SEE UKRAINE ON A15

D.C. shivers under an icy blanket of ‘snowcrete’



MATT MCCLAIN/THE WASHINGTON POST

A person navigates Franklin Park in downtown Washington on Thursday. Several days after a fierce winter storm dropped up to 9 inches of snow and sleet, freezing temperatures have left banks of ice and snow on nearly every sidewalk. We followed a snowplow driver on a 12-hour shift, block by block and mound by mound. **Story, B13**

Rationale for possible strikes on Iran is in flux

BY KAREN DEYOUNG

On the second day of January, as anti-government protests spread across Iran and there were early reports of demonstrators killed by Iranian security forces, President Donald Trump pledged to come to their rescue. “We are locked and loaded and ready to go,” he wrote on social media.

Less than two weeks later, as both the protests and the deaths had increased exponentially,

White House shifts focus from protests to nuclear program and U.S. bases

Trump called on the demonstrators to “KEEP PROTESTING — TAKE OVER YOUR INSTITUTIONS,” and pledged that “HELP IS ON THE WAY.”

The promise to aid civilians

suffering massive human rights abuses seemed a classic exercise of the Responsibility to Protect, the commitment undertaken unanimously by world governments, including the United States, at the United Nations more than a quarter-century ago and occasionally cited by previous U.S. presidents since then as a justification for far-flung military action.

Such reasoning seemed out of political character for Trump, who

promised an “America First” foreign policy that would end overseas entanglements and the historic U.S. role as international policeman and defender of democracy. Trump's second-term military strikes in Yemen, Nigeria and elsewhere, as well as threats to use force in places such as Greenland and Colombia, have sparked rumblings among his backers of creeping neoconservatism and ill-fated U.S. interventions in Afghanistan

SEE IRAN ON A14

Gabbard’s presence at Ga. FBI raid stirs unease

Lawmakers ask why DNI was in Fulton County, heart of 2020 vote claims

This article is by Ellen Nakashima, Warren P. Strobel, Ben Brusch, Jeremy Roebuck and Emily Davies

At a televised Cabinet meeting last August, President Donald Trump turned to his top intelligence official, noting that she had evidence of “how corrupt the 2020 election was,” and asked when she'd produce it.

“I will be the first to brief you once we have that information collected,” Director of National Intelligence Tulsi Gabbard replied.

Gabbard, who coordinates the nation's 18 spy agencies, has put “election integrity” and holding former government officials accountable for alleged election interference among her priorities.

Trump has long maintained that the 2020 election, which he lost to Joe Biden, was rigged. U.S. national security officials at the time said they found no evidence of widespread fraud, and numerous courts rejected claims of election irregularities as unfounded.

Though her office traditionally focuses on foreign intelligence and adversaries, Gabbard's unexplained appearance Wednesday evening at a warehouse in Fulton County, Georgia, while the FBI

was executing a search warrant revealed the extent to which her office has been involved in a domestic criminal investigation. Photographs confirming her presence stunned lawmakers, who on Thursday called for the Office of the Director of National Intelligence to urgently brief them on the matter.

“My constituents in Georgia, and I think much of the American public, are quite reasonably alarmed in asking questions after the Director of National Intelligence was spotted bizarrely and personally lurking in an FBI evidence truck in Fulton County, Georgia, yesterday,” Sen. Jon Ossoff (D-Georgia) said Thursday at an intelligence committee hearing for Trump's nominee to head the National Security Agency, Lt. Gen. Joshua Rudd. Ossoff questioned whether ODNi “is straying far outside of its lane.”

“Director Gabbard recognizes that election security is essential for the integrity of our republic and our nation's security. As DNI, she has a vital role in identifying vulnerabilities in our critical infrastructure and protecting against exploitation. ... President Trump's directive to secure our elections was clear, and DNI Gabbard has and will continue to take actions within her authorities, alongside our interagency partners, to support ensuring the integrity of our elections,” said ODNi Press Secretary Olivia

SEE GABBARD ON A6



ANADOLU/GETTY IMAGES

A Border Patrol agent scans a driver's face this month during an ICE operation in Minneapolis.

The powerful tools in ICE’s arsenal

High-tech gadgets provide many eyes on suspects and protesters alike

BY EVA DOU, ARTUR GALOCHA
AND KEVIN SCHAUL

Masks, guns and tactical gear are unmistakable hallmarks of Immigration and Customs Enforcement officers.

Less visible is an array of intrusive technologies helping ICE locate and track undocumented immigrants and, increasingly, citizens opposed to the government's deportation campaign.

These technologies, both visible and invisible, are transforming the front lines of immigration

enforcement and political protest across America today.

Federal immigration officers fanning out across Minnesota and other parts of the country are newly equipped with an array of state-of-the-art surveillance technologies, thanks to a bill passed last summer that transformed Immigration and Customs Enforcement into the country's most highly funded law enforcement agency. ICE has wasted no time spending its war chest, buying new tools ranging from biometric

SEE ICE ON A8

No deal reached on raids in Minn.

DHS, STATE LEADERS SEEK WAY FORWARD

Trump’s border czar sets conditions on drawdown

BY MARIA SACCHETTI,
KAREN TUMULTY,
AMY B WANG
AND JOANNA SLATER

President Donald Trump's border czar said Thursday that his team is working on a plan to “draw down” the number of federal immigration enforcement agents in the Minneapolis area and admitted that “certain improvements” could be made.

But Tom Homan said any scaling back in immigration raids hinges on increased state and local cooperation on enforcement with the Department of Homeland Security, and Minnesota's attorney general said they reached no such accord.

Attorney General Keith Ellison (D) said he had a “cordial” meeting with Homan on Wednesday to explain state law, to register the state's outrage over the fatal shootings of Alex Pretti and Renée Good, and to call for joint and transparent state and federal investigations into their deaths.

“I did not negotiate with Mr. Homan, come to any agreement, or offer any compromise on the goal of keeping Minnesotans safe,” Ellison said in a statement.

SEE MINNEAPOLIS ON A9

Senate: Funding deal with Trump reached, but short lapse likely. **A9**

Prosecutors: Handling of probes has some on verge of quitting. **A11**

Banfield proclaims innocence on stand

Accused of killing two, he testifies that he tried to stop attack on his wife

BY EMMA UBER

Brendan Banfield assumed his wife was having an affair when his mistress called to tell him she had seen a stranger entering his Northern Virginia home, he testified Thursday during his murder trial. After all, he said, they had both indulged in extramarital relationships — and he was months into an affair with the family's 22-year-old Brazilian au pair.

Prosecutors say the forbidden romance with the woman helping care for his daughter drove Banfield to orchestrate an elaborate plot to kill his wife and a man he lured to their bed from a fetish website so he would have someone to blame for her death. Banfield, telling his side of the story publicly for the first time Thursday, rejected their theory and testified that he interrupted a violent knife attack on his wife by shooting her attacker moments too late to save her life.

SEE BANFIELD ON A11

IN THE NEWS

Selling Venezuelan oil The United States awarded \$500 million in contracts to two companies that were previously prosecuted for bribery schemes. **A3**

‘Defund’ no more A top Democratic think tank urges the party to strike a tougher tone on crime by spending more on police. **A5**

THE NATION **A nonpartisan** estimate found the National Guard deployments cost nearly \$500 million. **A4**
The cost of health care is Americans' leading pocketbook anxiety, a poll found. **A4**

THE WORLD **Friction** has emerged between Trump and Venezuela's leading opposition figure. **A14**
A former first lady was sentenced in South Korea, where leaders are often prosecuted. **A15**

THE ECONOMY **A Waymo** robotaxi hit a child outside a school in California, triggering a safety investigation and raising safety fears. **A17**
A lawsuit claims WhatsApp has a major security problem, but experts are skeptical and the company denies the claim. **A17**

STYLE **Louisiana** Gov. Jeff Landry does double duty as the U.S.'s hype man for Greenland. **B1**

SPORTS **The NBA** will announce its all-star reserves Sunday, and injuries to a handful of big-name players will lend intrigue to the calls. **B7**

THE REGION **After her** 28-year-old son's death, a woman's quest for records on D.C. 911 response times leads to a lawsuit. **B13**

WEEKEND **Are you ready** to lose yourself in the rhythm? At these four new clubs in D.C., the parties go all night long.

BUSINESS NEWS.....A16
COMICS.....B4
OBITUARIES.....B16
OPINION PAGES.....B18
TELEVISION.....B6
WORLD NEWS.....A13

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The Washington Post
Year 149, No. 54477

